

PhD candidate in computational astrophysics with expertise in Python and C++ programming, designing numerical models for complex physical processes, quantitative data analysis, modeling stochastic processes, and large-scale parallelized computing.

EDUCATION & PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Columbia University, NY, USA

B.A. in Physics and Astronomy (GPA 4.06/4.3)

September 2018–May 2022

Advisors: Greg Bryan, Drummond Fielding, David Kipping

Awards & Honors: Summa Cum Laude, Departmental Honors (Physics), Phi Beta Kappa, John Jay

Scholar, Dean's List

Center for Computational Astrophysics, Flatiron Institute, NY, USA

Guest Researcher

May 2022–August 2022

University of California, Santa Barbara, CA, USA

M.A. and Ph.D. in Astrophysics (GPA 3.9/4.0)

September 2022–Present

Advisor: S. Peng Oh

Awards & Honors: James and Mary Jo Hartle Graduate Fellowship

SKILLS

- Programming: Python; C++; Linux/Bash; MPI; OpenMP.
- Scientific Computing: Computational Fluid Simulations; Large-Scale Parallel Computing; Numerical Techniques for Solving Differential Equations; Monte Carlo Methods; Stochastic Processes.
- Building Quantitative Models to Explain Noisy Real-World and Simulation Data; Order of Magnitude Calculations.

SELECTED PROJECTS & PUBLICATIONS

- **Survival and Evolution of Molecular Gas in Galactic Outflows** (September 2022–April 2024)

Designed large-scale 3D hydrodynamic simulations using the C++ based framework [Athena++](#) to study molecular-temperature cold clouds in hot galactic outflows. Addressed the computational challenge of resolving gas spanning 5 orders of magnitude in temperature and density. Developed computationally efficient numerical schemes for radiation self-shielding and dust evolution, performed high-resolution parallelized simulations on HPC clusters using 10k+ node-hours, and optimized workflows for computational performance, scalability, and numerical stability.

Published paper: **Zirui Chen** and S. Peng Oh, [“The Survival and Entrainment of Molecules and Dust in Galactic Winds”](#), 2024, Monthly Notices of the Royal Astronomical Society.

- **Analytic Model for Turbulent Radiative Mixing Layers** (June 2020–June 2023)

Derived partial differential equations to model turbulent mixing layers that form at multiphase gas interfaces due to Kelvin-Helmholtz instability and developed a novel parameterization of turbulence-driven conductivity and viscosity. Implemented numerical integration schemes in Python to obtain physically motivated solutions that reproduce large-scale 3D simulation results in minutes instead of thousands of node-hours.

Published paper: **Zirui Chen**, Drummond Fielding, and Greg Bryan, [“The Anatomy of a Turbulent Radiative Mixing Layer: Insights from an Analytic Model with Turbulent Conduction and Viscosity”](#), 2023, The Astrophysical Journal.

- **Modeling Multi-Phase, Turbulent Flows Using Stochastic Differential Equations** (May 2026–Present)
Developing a Fokker–Planck-based stochastic differential equation framework to model the temperature probability distribution function of multi-phase turbulent gas. Inferred effective drift and diffusion coefficients from high-resolution 3D simulations.
- **Temperature Structure and Topology of Multi-Phase, Turbulent Astrophysical Gas** (April 2024–Present)
Designed high-resolution stirring box and mixing layer simulations to study the temperature structure of multi-phase gas. Numerically implemented key physical processes including turbulence driving, interstellar heating and cooling, magnetic fields, and thermal conduction. Applied topological concepts to quantify complex interface geometry and explain the abundance of thermally unstable gas observed in astrophysical systems.
Published paper: **Zirui Chen** and S. Peng Oh, “[From Clumps to Sheets: Geometry Controls the Temperature PDF of Multi-Phase Gas](#)”, 2026, Submitted to The Open Journal of Astrophysics.
- **Explaining the Universal X-ray to H α Surface Brightness Correlation** (January 2026–Present)
Quantified the morphology of multiphase gas in turbulent flows to explain the long-standing observational puzzle of a universal X-ray to H α surface brightness ratio observed across astrophysical systems spanning wide ranges of lengthscale, pressure, and velocity. Developed a passive-scalar scheme in hydrodynamic simulations to quantify how turbulence regulates the abundance of X-ray-emitting gas.
Published paper: **Zirui Chen**, S. Peng Oh, et al. “[Clumps in a Cocoon: Geometry and Mixing Set the Universal X-ray to H \$\alpha\$ Surface Brightness Ratio](#)”, 2026, Submitted to Monthly Notices of the Royal Astronomical Society Letter.
- **Other Significant Publications**
Zirui Chen, Zixuan Peng, Kate H. R. Rubin et al., “[Modeling Emission-Line Surface Brightness in a Multiphase Galactic Wind: An O VI Case Study](#)”, 2026, Monthly Notices of the Royal Astronomical Society.
Zirui Chen and David Kipping, “[The Number of Transits Per Epoch for Transiting Misaligned Circumbinary Planets](#)”, 2022, Monthly Notices of the Royal Astronomical Society.
Zixuan Peng, Crystal Martin, **Zirui Chen**, Drummond B. Fielding, et al., “[Physical Origins of Outflowing Cold Clouds in Local Star-Forming Dwarf Galaxies](#)”, 2025, The Astrophysical Journal.

GRANTS & PROPOSALS

- Hubble Space Telescope Cycle 32 Archival Research Proposal, ID 17860, **Co-PI** October 2024
“Interface: A New Tool for Generating Absorption and Emission Spectra from Multi-Phase Mixing Layers” .
Received funding for a senior graduate student for 6 months (**\$50,000.00**) amid significant funding cuts at NASA.
- Non-thermal Processes at Multiphase Boundaries in the Interstellar and Circum-galactic Medium, ACCESS PHY240194, **Co-PI** October 2024
107.6k node hours and **200kGB archival storage** on the Stampede3 computing cluster at UT Austin. The estimated value of these awarded resources is **\$63,800.00**.
- Turbulence and Thermally Unstable Gas, ACCESS PHY240001, **PI** January 2024
400k ACCESS credits on 40+ NSF supported computing clusters in the US.
- Molecular Cloud in Galactic Winds, ACCESS PHY230107, **PI** July 2023
400k ACCESS credits on 40+ NSF supported computing clusters in the US.

INVITED TALKS, TEACHING, & PROFESSIONAL SERVICE

- Referee for [Monthly Notices of the Royal Astronomical Society](#).
- Invited talks at [Astronomy on Tap](#) (Astronomy Talk at a Bar), [Carnegie Observatories](#), [the Flatiron Institute](#) (Center for Computational Astrophysics), and [UCSB](#).
- Teaching Assistant for astronomy and experimental physics courses at UCSB (September 2022 to Present).

- Mentored undergraduate student to conduct research in computational astrophysics (January 2024 - June 2024).
- Volunteered at Columbia Astronomy Outreach Program (September 2018 - May 2022).